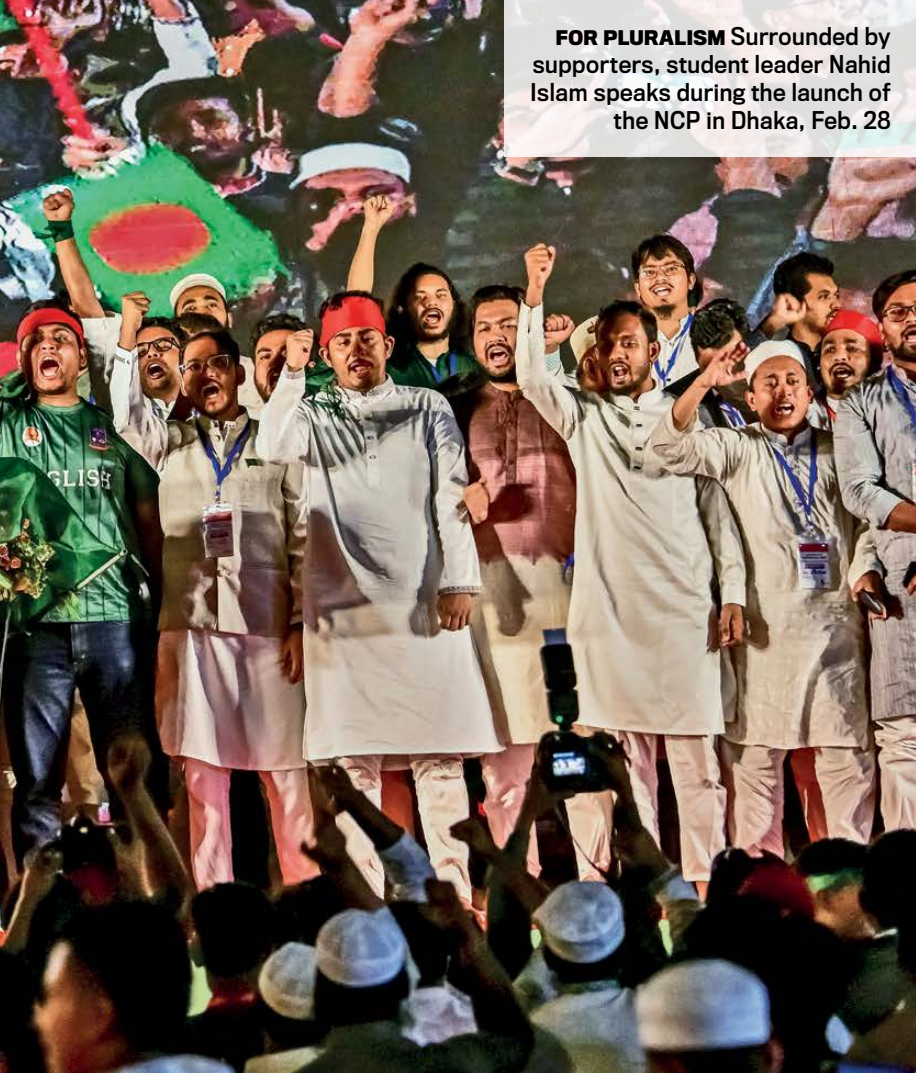


FOR PLURALISM Surrounded by supporters, student leader Nahid Islam speaks during the launch of the NCP in Dhaka, Feb. 28

SOME SUSPECT THAT ISLAMISTS MIGHT BE USING THE NCP AS A VEHICLE FOR POLITICAL LEGITIMACY. OTHERS THINK THE INTERIM GOVERNMENT ITSELF IS BEHIND IT TO NEUTRALISE THE OPPOSITION

Sources allege the new NCP was a strategic move by the students to maintain a centrist identity and avoid being labelled as an Islamist party. However, others suggest the Jamaat was behind the backlash over Muntasir's inclusion.

A former Indian envoy to Bangladesh says Islamists might be using the NCP as a vehicle for political legitimacy. "Groups like Jamaat know that they will not get more than 5 per cent of the vote by themselves. But with student activists at the forefront, there will be some legitimacy for these extremists," he says. Indeed, New Delhi remains cautious of any potential Islamist resurgence under the guise of a new political movement. The diplomat adds that irrespective of what the student leaders say, most are backed by Islamists.

Adding another layer of intrigue, a Bangladeshi diplomat hinted at potential government involvement in the NCP's launch. "We have proof that the (interim) government by proxy has helped organise the launch event of the NCP. Should a sitting government play such a role?"

If the allegations are true, the NCP can be seen as a strategic project aimed at reshaping Bangladesh's political landscape in a controlled manner rather than an independent movement. Critics argue that the interim government is seeking to neutralise the Bangladesh Nationalist Party (BNP)—the one national party still standing since the Awami League is in disarray after Hasina's ouster—and fragment the opposition by fostering NCP's rise.

While the BNP welcomed the NCP's formation, its leaders are watching the party's internal rifts closely. However, a BNP insider says that their main priority is the return of acting chairman Tarique Rahman. "We need his presence now more than ever because we need to prepare for the polls and also set a counter-narrative before the students gain more traction," he admits.

NCP leaders, including Anik Roy, a Left politician, emphasises the party's strength. "The Jatiyo Nagorik Committee has units in more than 300 sub-districts, towns and cities. We will scrutinise these existing members and select the right people for the party's district and sub-district committees," he claims. With Bangladesh expected to hold an election within a year, the NCP plans to launch a nationwide long march and start its election campaign by April.

According to Bangladeshi political historian Altaf Parvez, the students have an opportunity to fill the liberal space that is running empty. "But the way they have operated in the last seven months and their populist approach since the NCP's launch, it can be said that they will take a right-of-centre approach," he says.

The NCP has ambitions to emerge as a progressive force, yet is succumbing to conservative pressure over Muntasir. It claims to be centrist, yet is accused of Islamist infiltration; an independent movement, but charges of government backing creates suspicion. The coming months will be crucial for the NCP as Bangladesh moves towards a national election. The stakes for democracy, political inclusivity and stability have never been higher. ■